

However, if you have X10 products and are thinking of bringing in UPB for its advantages, you are in for a disappointment because UPB and X10 products aren't compatible. So, if you wish to add UPB products, you'll require a special controller which could communicate with both.

Also, the reliability factor aside, UPB is still a hard fit with newer wireless technologies like Wi-Fi and smartphones. The bad news continues with the fact that the platform provides relatively low bandwidth, meaning the performance wouldn't be as fast as you wished. There's no encryption with UPB, making it less secure compared to wireless. Also, the technical complexity of the system makes setting it up a jarring exercise on the nerves. Bear with us for we have one more bit of bad news – the number of UPB compatible devices is far lesser than for other technologies.



Not quite up there where you want

INSTEON

INSTEON was introduced in 2005 and its devices can communicate over power lines as well as wirelessly. Another advantage of Insteon is that it's X10 compatible. So, users have the option to add wireless capability to their existing X10 network. Such an exercise could be efficient as well as cost-effective in transitioning completely to wireless. In fact, the technology is supportive of those without much know-how in home automation, making it feasible for non-technical people to set up and/or add devices to a network.

As for devices, some 200 distinct Insteon-enabled home automation devices are available, including hub controllers. Another cool thing is that Insteon devices needn't be enrolled into a home automation network as the devices join the network as soon as they are powered up. This simplifies the installation process.

An Insteon network can be quite expansive and it's not unusual to see over 400 devices in a single installation. The dual-band mesh network of Insteon effectively converts all powerline-operated devices into repeaters. This improves the signal range manifold.

Z-Wave

Z-Wave is among the most popular wireless home automation protocols. It runs on the 908.42 MHz band. Compared to the band used by most house-